

Chapter 8

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- The concept of the linguistic marketplace
- The role of media representatives as linguistic authorities
- Spin, propaganda, and framing in the media
- How Sarah Palin's language was framed by the media
- How Barack Obama's language was framed by the media

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. This chapter opened with a quote from Mark Crispin Miller who is associated with The Project on Media Ownership at Johns Hopkins University. Use the internet to learn about the project, its goals and approaches, and consider Miller's comment in that context before discussing it. In your first reaction, did you feel Miller's position was polemic and exaggerated, or did you accept the concepts more easily? What factors in your own life and experience inform your reactions to such statements?

Sample answer: My initial reaction was that his argument was exaggerated and extreme since he used Nazi Germany in his comparison. However, I see his point that in the U.S. many of us don't realize that the information we receive is controlled and chosen for us. I am very aware that the news we get is selected for us because there have been many ongoing news stories that interested me that never seemed to be followed up on appropriately. For example, I might miss the news one day, and then I would realize that I never found out what happened with such-and-such story. Sometimes even with internet searches I have had a hard time finding out the resolution of an ongoing story. This made me wonder if the news networks abandoned that story because it was no longer garnering them high enough ratings, which made me think more critically about who chooses the news we get and why.

2. Consider this statement made by a National Public Radio representative. Note the use of passive constructions and ambiguous "they believe" claims. What does the speaker mean specifically by the words clearest and crisp? What is the unstated opposite?

NPR is considered by many to be the standard bearer for Standard American English. Listeners from around the country and around the world say that they find NPR English is the clearest and most comprehensible broadcast English available. They can hear that crisp American English on NPR member stations, on their Web sites, on line at npr.org or on the listeners' shortwave receivers. (Dvorkin 2005)

Sample answer: The use of the words *clearest* and *crisp* reveal that the writer of this statement firmly believes the standard language ideology that considers *SAE to be superior to other

varieties of English. The words *clearest* and *crisp* tell the listener that the language variety used on NPR is best dialect for communication because it is the most succinct and easy-to-understand variety. The implication here is that other varieties of English are sloppy, inefficient, and difficult to understand.

3. The following excerpt from *The Providence Journal Bulletin* is presented as news. How does it incorporate stages in the underlying language subordination process?

No matter how qualified a person is, a voice twisted by regional or ethnic influences can be a stumbling block socially and professionally. If others can't understand you or your words are too richly flavored with down-home spice, you could find all your skill and intelligence thwarted by a telltale tongue. ("Voice of success silences dialect," The Providence Journal Bulletin April 1994)

Sample answer: This piece of "news" reinforces standard language ideology by warning speakers of nonstandard varieties that choosing not to conform to the standard will lead to very negative consequences. If this strategy is successful, then speakers of nonstandard dialects will come to devalue their language variety as well, perhaps taking steps to conform to the standard and maintaining the social status quo that privileges speakers of some varieties over speakers of other varieties.

4. What is the role of the news media in today's society? What rights and responsibilities do the media have? How have those things changed over the last fifty years? Consider this newspaper excerpt from a short report on the front page of *The Evening Record* (Ellensburg, Washington) of November 22, 1937, in your reply:

President Roosevelt refused today to concede he used bad grammar. Shown an open letter by Professor Janet R. Aiken of Columbia University questioning his grammar in recent speeches, the president smilingly blamed newsmen who reported his extemporaneous remarks. ... In her letter, Dr. Aiken wanted to know: "Did you learn how to [talk] that way at Groton or Harvard or where?"

Sample answer: I think the media has changed over the years in its approach to what it feels entitled to report on. For example, from this excerpt, it seems that President Roosevelt thought the media would only be reporting on his prepared statements and did not expect his offhand remarks to be reported as news. That is extremely different from the expectations of the media today, where offhand remarks are scrutinized by the media and the public.

5. What does "manufactured authority" or "manufacturing authority" mean? What would be its opposite?

Sample answer: If an institution, such as the news industry, has *manufactured authority*, it means that that institution has authority because it has set itself up as the authority. I suppose the opposite of *manufactured authority* would be authority that was thrust upon an institution by the public, without the institution seeking such authority.

6. Consider the following quotes from newspaper reports on accent reduction or elimination classes. What kind of imagery is used? Are logical fallacies evident?

January 1989
“Speak English, Troops”

Speech pathologists trained to combat foreign accents are doing big business in multi-ethnic California. ...

The influx of Asian and Hispanic immigrants has created strong demand for English-language training and accent-modification courses. Many foreign born professionals believe that their accents impede their careers, and they are prepared to pay hundreds of dollars to free their English from traces of their homelands. ... A person with a heavy accent may start his or her career in a technical job where few speaking skills are required, but advancement usually brings a greater emphasis on communication. An employee who is difficult to understand may be shrugged off as stupid or simply passed over in favor of someone who speaks clear English.

Sample answer: The major logical fallacy that I see in this excerpt is the false choice fallacy. The writer is basically saying that Asian and Hispanic immigrants have two choices: they can try to conform to *SAE, or they can retain their L2 accents and potentially suffer in their careers. This false choice fallacy seems to be a big part of the language subordination process – the focus is on the negative consequences of nonconformity and the positive consequences of assimilation rather than exploring why L2 accents are an issue in society in the first place or how people can have successful careers while maintaining their L2 accents.

7. Read John McWhorter's editorial response to the public controversy around Senator Reid's “no Negro dialect” comment (McWhorter January 9, 2010) at <http://www.tnr.com/blog/john-mcwhorter/reids-three-little-words-the-log-our-own-eye>). McWhorter is a sociolinguist and an African American. Does anything surprise you about his position? In what points might you agree?

Sample answer: What surprises me most about this article is that McWhorter focuses more on defending Senator Reid than critiquing America's attitudes about AAVE. I agree with McWhorter that crucifying Reid for saying what most of America thinks is hypocritical, but at the same time, Reid's voicing of America's linguistic prejudice provides a good opportunity to open up critical discussion of this prejudice.

8. How has the meaning of the word spin changed over the last twenty years? What do you understand it to be? Why do people choose to say “That's just spin,” rather than explain the beliefs that cause them to reject the message?

Sample answer: I understand *spin* to be the presentation of information in a way that influences the interlocutor's analysis of the information. I think most all communicated information has some amount of spin on it since the information must be passed through a human being who

chooses the grammatical constructions and vocabulary words with which to transmit this information.

I think people dismiss messages as spin rather than explaining why they reject the message because it is much easier to label messages we dislike as being too subjective to be taken seriously. Constructing a critical opposition to an argument takes much more effort.

9. *Imagine you walk into a meeting room and somebody comes up to you, looks you up and down, and smiling broadly says, “Congratulations! You buttoned your shirt correctly!” How is this like (or not like) African-American objections to being called articulate?*

Sample answer: This situation is similar to whites calling African Americans articulate because it implies that the speaker expected that I wouldn’t have been able to button my shirt correctly, just like how calling an African American articulate can imply that the speaker expected that an African Americans would not be articulate.

10. *Consider this idea from Tim Wise’s Between Barack and a Hard Place: Racism and White Denial in the Age of Obama (2009) Wise proposes that racism has evolved to look like “enlightened exceptionalism ... that allows for and even celebrates the achievements of individual persons of color ... because they are seen as different from a less appealing, even pathological Black or brown rule” (p. 9). Beyond the use of the word “articulate” in describing President Obama, is there other evidence of this kind of enlightened exceptionalism in the media’s commentary on Obama’s language, or more generally?*

Sample answer: Yes, I think there is. For example, public figures (such as Joe Biden and George Bush) have commented on Obama’s attractiveness, intelligence, charm and charisma, and even his cleanliness in ways that seem to celebrate Obama as an exception to the rest of the African American population. Describing Obama in these ways demonstrates that, while much of the public has embraced Barack Obama, racism against African Americans in general remains.

From the website

Audio

1. *Listen to the sample of Sarah Palin’s Alaskan dialect. Chapter 8 describes how both Sarah Palin and her detractors use her dialect as a tool to frame her in different ways. What do you think about her dialect? Which frame does her dialect reinforce for you?*

Sample answer: Before reading Chapter 8, for me Sarah Palin’s accent reinforced the frame that her detractors had created, which considered her accent to be part of a negative, country bumpkin persona rather than a positive “regular person” persona. However, after reading Chapter 8, I will now think more critically about my reaction to her accent and the prejudice in my reluctance to take her seriously based on her accent.

2. *Listen to the samples of African American English and English with an Asian L2 accent found in the International Dialects of English Archive. These language varieties are mentioned in the*

discussion of mocking on page 137. Have you ever heard anybody mock AAVE or Asian accents? What was the context? What did this mocking reveal about the mocker's language ideology?

Sample answer: Yes, I have heard people mock both of these language varieties in several contexts. For example, I have heard people use mock AAVE when trying to “act tough” when describing a confrontation or a possible confrontation. This use of mock AAVE reveals linguistic stereotypes that position AAVE as a variety suitable for a restricted set of uses, such as confrontation and indignation.

I have seen and heard people mock Asian accents by substituting ‘r’ and ‘l.’ These mocking uses of Asian accents were all intended to be humorous and reveal the language ideology that Asian L2 accents are funny rather than legitimate channels for communication.

Video

“Palin / Hillary Open”

Saturday Night Live

http://www.nbc.com/saturday-night-live/video/palin_hillary_open/656281

1. How does Tina Fey’s parody of Sarah Palin frame Palin? How does Fey’s imitation of Palin’s language use reinforce this frame?

Sample answer: Fey’s parody frames Palin as a small-town bumpkin, and Fey’s imitation of Palin’s accent reinforces this frame. By imitating Palin’s regional dialect and using some of Palin’s well-known quotes (e.g. seeing Alaska from her house and the lipstick joke), Fey reinforces the portrayal of Palin as folksy, rustic, and unsophisticated. The parody sends the message that Palin is unfit for the vice presidency in part because of the way she speaks, which draws upon the stereotypes the skit writers expected the audience would have about the rural, working-class people.

“Is Calling Obama ‘articulate’ bad?”

MSNBC News, 3/09/2007

<http://www.bing.com/videos/watch/video/is-calling-obama-articulate-bad/6yy5el7>

1. What do you think about Obama being called ‘articulate’ on the campaign trail after watching this clip and reading Chapter 8?

Sample answer: Before watching this video clip and reading Chapter 8, I thought that Obama was often called ‘articulate’ as a way to contrast his public speaking skills with Bush, who was rather notoriously inarticulate. However, I no longer feel this way because if my original interpretation was correct, then many of the candidates would have also frequently been described as ‘articulate,’ but they were not. I now think that the constant references to Obama as an articulate person indicate that some people did not expect an African American to be so well-spoken, which reveals the prejudices and discriminatory language ideologies that remain pervasive in society.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Have your students interview a handful of participants and ask these participants to describe their opinion of Sarah Palin's accent. Does the accent have positive or negative associations for these participants? Is there any connection between a participant's political orientation and his or her reaction to Palin's accent?
2. Have your students ask ten people how they would describe President Obama and bring their results in to share with the class. Ask them to discuss their findings in light of the material in Chapter 8. Is there anything that can be concluded about language ideology based on the results? Do the students see any signs of enlightened exceptionalism in the responses they received?
3. Ask the students to reflect on the role of language variation in the 2008 presidential election and to speculate how things could have been different. How do they think the election (and the media coverage of the election) may have been different if Barack Obama had spoken more AAVE during the campaign? What if Sarah Palin had sounded like she was from Ohio or California? What do their speculations reveal about their perceptions of language ideologies in America?
4. If there is an election happening while your course is in session, ask your students to follow the news coverage of the election to look for any mention of the candidates' language use. Have them reflect in an essay or in class on what the media said (or didn't say) about language variation in the election and what that means in terms of language ideology.
5. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.